

Jailbook

If you are displeased about something it might not be a good idea to be frank about it, especially on Facebook. Four Lebanese university students found it out the hard way when they had to spend a week in the cooler for ridiculing the singing talents of a young lady.

facebook

Know Thy Phone

Do you need advice in understanding your phone, the way you do when selecting a wine. If you are in Japan, the answer is yes. Japanese handsets are getting so complicated that they are considering licenses for experts who will walk customers through their handset purchase. Phew!



Escape

MUSIC MANIA

Sharing Blues

We've been talking a lot about file sharing in these pages over the months, and regular readers following the script would know that RIAA, the recording industry body in US has been doggedly pursuing individuals who have uploaded, or downloaded pirated music. They've slapped court cases, won hefty fines and have generally gone about treating music fans like criminals—guilty until proven innocent. Readers will also recall that while RIAA swears it's doing all this dirty work for the benefit of musicians and artists, the supposedly affected parties have said that they are not happy with RIAA's tactics and prefer that music companies change their business model and adapt to the times.

Recently, the RIAA got another bloody nose in its ongoing slugfest with the Common Man, when two of its cases were shot down by

the courts. Both these are unrelated, but they serve to underscore the underhanded and often desperate tactics in this campaign. In the first case defendant Tanya Andersen, a disabled single mother had to face mafia-style tactics like invasion of privacy and attempts to clandestinely contact her eight-year-old daughter to dig up files-haring skeletons. After a long and two year wait, the concerned courts have dismissed the allegations of RIAA that Andersen was pirating gangsta rap on the P2P site KaZaA, and awarded her the hefty lawyer's dues. Additionally, it allowed a class action lawsuit filed by her to go through, which essentially means that anyone who was accused by RIAA of file-sharing can join the lawsuit and claim compensation.

Which we recommend the Howells to do. They have been accused of sharing music, again over

KaZaA. However, they have not been accused of uploading that particular file. In case you want to know how anyone could share something which was not uploaded, let us clear things up. RIAA—in its infinite wisdom—has decreed that even if a song is in a shared folder named, say, "For KaZaA", from where it could be theoretically shared this would consist of committing the heinous crime of music piracy. If you intend to illegally distribute music, you would be screwed: this is RIAA's view of the perfect world. The Electronic Frontier Foundation (EFF)—the privacy watchdog in the cyber world—has thrown its hat in the ring and has basically told the judge that RIAA is spouting bovine excreta. We hope the judge agrees, and the world remains imperfect. And while we are at it, we do hope the RIAA gets kicked where it hurts for their copyright Nazism.

Whatever Happened To...

Usenet

"Disusenet," it might be better called today. It's more probable that you haven't, but you might just have heard about Usenet, and thought it was an old-style bulletin board system (BBS) or possibly a Web site where people posted things on various topics. Actually, it's not a BBS (though it resembles one); it is not an organisation, nor a public utility, nor an academic network, nor is it a software. According to one Web site, Usenet is "the set of people who exchange articles tagged with one or more universally-recognised labels, called 'newsgroups.'"

For more than 20 years, Usenet was considered the best way to read and post messages over the Internet. The network grew into thousands of discussion groups; topics ranged from Olive Ridley turtle conservation to scuba diving in the Thames.

So what's happened to Usenet? One is blogs: they're more user-friendly, and prettier. Second, the majority of Usenet newsgroups are now populated by un-read-worthy content, off-topic stuff, and spam. In 2005, AOL stopped access to Usenet.

Usenet is very old-style. A certain site about Usenet sternly tells you: "Furthermore, the people who run the news systems are called news administrators, not sysops. If you want to be understood, be accurate." Today, no-one has the time for (or can stand) this kind of uppity, censorious attitude.

DigiPick of the month

My t-shirt just hung!



Last month's winner:

Vaibhav Jayant Deshpande
Navi Mumbai

Participate and win next month:

The Essential Guide to User Interface Design

by Wilbert O. Galitz

Published by

WILEY-INDIA

WIN!

Send in your entry and you could win an exciting gift by sharing an amusing picture with a tech angle to it. The picture should have been shot by you, and should not have been published anywhere earlier. E-mail your picture with "DigiPick" in the subject line, mentioning your postal address, **on or before the 20th of this month** to digipick@thinkdigit.com. One prize-winning picture will be published each month.

JOB GONE

Blog roll

The annual Consumer Electronics Show (CES) at Las Vegas is where thousands of people from all over the world gather together to gawk at new consumer electronics products. We know that part. Products like huge 150-inch LCDs, sleek laptops, booming music players—about 20,000 products in all, on the brink of flooding the world's stores in the coming months. Naturally, the people who visit this Mecca of electronics are pumped up, salivating over the new electronics that are likely to replace the same products we bought a few months ago. All right, so we know that part too.

CES being what it is, companies try very hard to sell their products. They go to great lengths to tom-tom the fabulous features, give painstaking demonstrations and generally try to make everyone—especially the media—believe that their TV, MP3 player, or computer

is the best thing created this side of the wheel. And those slick salesmen do manage to achieve what they started out to do—in most cases. TV displays play an important role in this shock-and-awe campaign, and if in the middle of a fabulous presentation your display suddenly conks out, you would be mighty ticked. And if that happens not once, but multiple times without anything apparently wrong with the hardware, you would be justified in thinking a poltergeist was haunting your system.

You'd never think that a TV-B-Gone remote is behind these blackouts, though—nobody could be that immature. TV-B-Gones, incidentally, are used to shut off annoying TV screens when they're disturbing your meditations on the great mysteries of life. Okay, we made that up, but everyone agrees that idiot boxes can get very annoying sometimes. However, such a remote was never intended to black out screens in the middle of a product demonstration—but

no one told the bloggers at Gizmodo that. They went around merrily clicking their remotes and shutting down whole walls of displays, leaving the people in charge with a what-the-heck-happened expression on their faces. The cheeky bloggers also disrupted a Motorola presentation twice, leaving the presenter with an undoubtedly bad taste in the mouth. This was then posted on Gizmodo.com. And all hell broke loose.

Ironically, most of the brickbats came from other bloggers, not the corporate types. The blogging community has been fighting hard for passes that are usually given out to members of the fourth estate, and it's only recently that they have managed to get accreditation as "real" journalists. They fear that such antics from members of their tribe would endanger their reputation, and they would be barred from all future events. That, or face strip searches. The Gizmodo staffer who had his finger on the remote has already been banned for life

People Who Changed Computing

Talk!

His is one of those names you can't afford not to be familiar with: a multi-faceted "computer genius," Briton Donald Davies invented Packet Switching (we're hoping you aren't wondering what that is). In 1965, while at the UK's National Physical Laboratory, he saw (it wasn't obvious to everyone at the time) that computers would be more useful if they could talk to each other. He went on to develop a system that allowed machines to send "packets" of information backward and forward over public telecommunications networks. Small chunks were sent separately so as to minimise the risk of congestion. The ARPA in the US liked it so much that they straightaway incorporated it into the ARPANET—and Packet Switching remains the basis of the Internet.

After graduating from Imperial College London, Davies joined a small team led by Alan Turing (again, we're hoping you aren't wondering who that is!), which was developing computers. The group's work led to the Pilot ACE computer; it was one of the first few electronic stored-program digital computers in the world. Davies had done much of the detailed design and development of the machine, as well as that of its full-fledged successor.

Davies was one of the lucky few pioneers who saw his work come into full fruition: he died in 2000 when the Internet was up and running, so to speak.



Don Davies

Win!

My Desktop

No Winner!
Better luck next time!

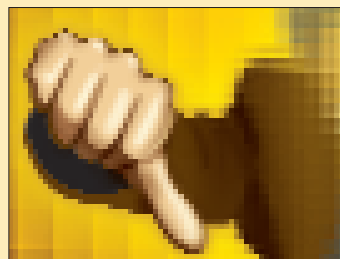
Participate in this contest and win next month

3D Animation and Filmmaking using Game Engines

by Paul Marino

Published by

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Send us your desktop with a description of how you made it to mydesktop@thinkdigit.com with the subject "My Desktop", and tell us your postal address, too.